Class 8 Social Science – Chapter 1

Natural Resources and Their Use

Complete Question–Answer Guide | Simple English | Based on your uploaded textbook, Exploring Society: India and Beyond, Grade 8, Part 1 (2026–27)

इस अध्याय के अंत में दिए गए सभी पाँच प्रश्नों के उत्तर, प्रत्येक टॉपिक से महत्वपूर्ण प्रश्न-उत्तर, उदाहरण, केस स्टडी और परीक्षा की तैयारी के लिए अतिरिक्त प्रश्न नीचे सरल अंग्रेजी में दिए गए हैं। उत्तरों में पाठ्यपुस्तक की शब्दावली और जानकारी को प्राथमिकता दी गई है।

Part 1: Answers to all textbook questions

Q1. What can make what is today a renewable resource non-renewable tomorrow? Describe some actions that can prevent this from happening.

Answer: A renewable resource can become non-renewable if we use it faster than nature can replace it. For example, cutting trees faster than new trees grow can destroy forests. Taking groundwater faster than rain can refill it can cause water shortages.

We can prevent this by planting trees, saving water, harvesting rainwater, preventing pollution and using resources carefully.

Q2. Name five ecosystem functions that serve humans.

Answer: Five ecosystem functions that serve humans are:

1. Trees produce oxygen.
2. Forests filter water.
3. Forests prevent soil erosion.
4. Forests provide habitats for animals.
5. Plants support pollination, which helps crops grow.

Q3. What are renewable resources? How are they different from non-renewable ones? What can people do to ensure that renewable resources continue to be available for our use and that of future generations? Give two examples.

Answer: Renewable resources are natural resources that can be renewed or replaced by natural processes over time. Examples are sunlight and wind.

Non-renewable resources take a very long time to form and cannot be replaced as quickly as we use them. Examples are coal and petroleum.

People can save renewable resources by using them sustainably, planting trees, harvesting rainwater and preventing pollution. They should also avoid wasting water and electricity.

Two examples are:

- Forests: Plant new trees and do not cut trees faster than they grow.
- Groundwater: Collect rainwater and use water carefully.

Q4. Identify cultural practices in your home and neighbourhood that point to mindfulness in the use of natural resources.

Answer: Some cultural practices that show care for natural resources are:

1. Worshipping trees and plants such as Tulasi.
2. Offering water to the Sun as a mark of respect and gratitude.
3. Protecting sacred groves and forests.
4. Reusing water and avoiding waste.
5. Using natural materials and organic manure in farming.

These practices encourage respect for nature and careful use of resources.

Q5. What are some considerations to keep in mind in the production of goods for our current use?

Answer: While producing goods, we should keep the following points in mind:

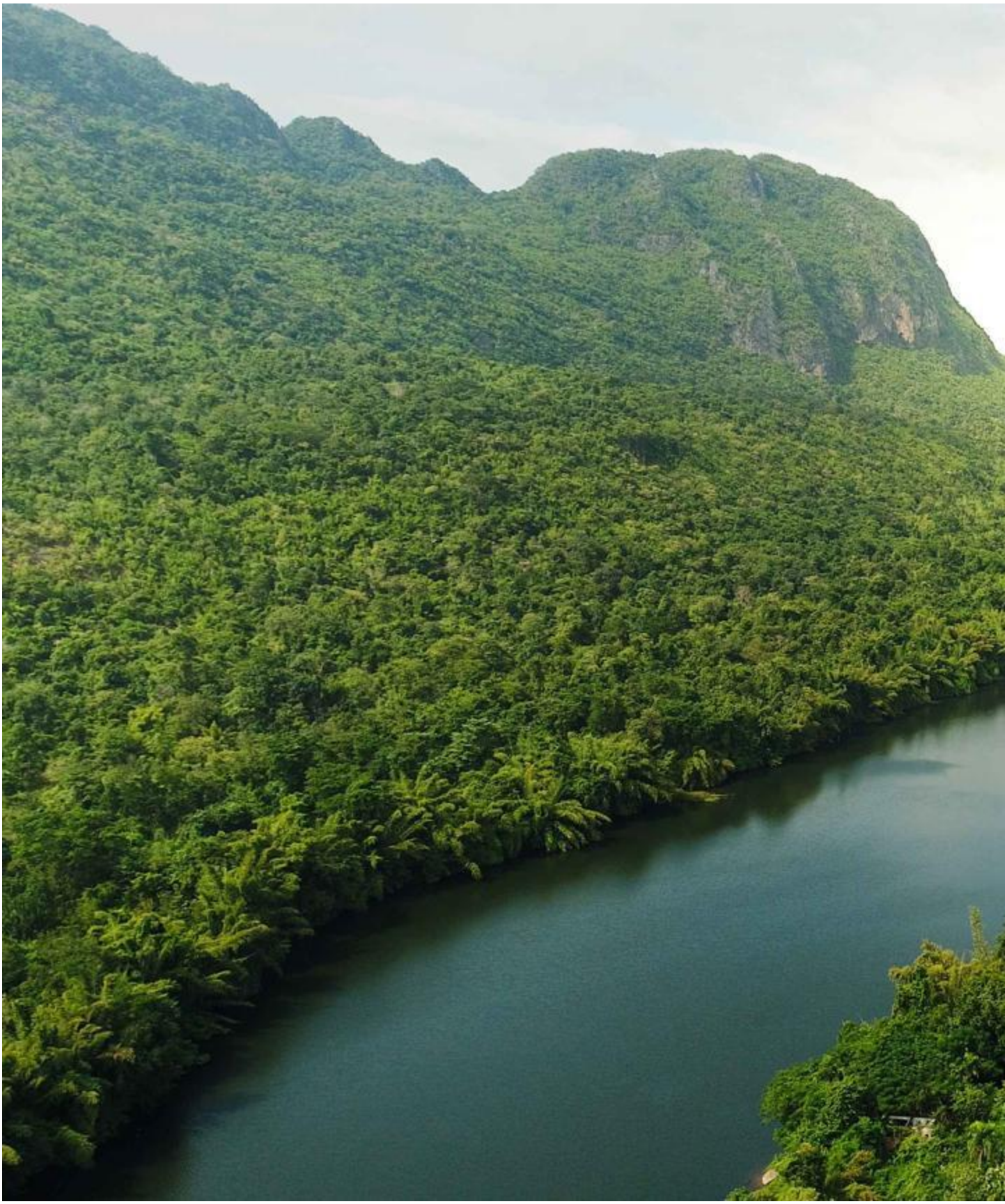
1. Use natural resources carefully.
2. Reduce air, water and soil pollution.
3. Avoid unnecessary waste.
4. Use recycled and environmentally friendly materials.
5. Protect forests, water and biodiversity.
6. Prefer renewable energy wherever possible.
7. Consider the needs of future generations.
8. Use traditional knowledge and modern technology to make production more sustainable.

Part 2: Important Questions and Answers from Every Topic

Topic 1: When Does Nature Become a Resource?

Q1. What is Nature?

Answer: Nature includes all living and non-living things in our environment that have not been created by humans.



Q2. What are natural resources?

Answer: Natural resources are materials and substances that occur in nature and are valuable to humans. Examples are air, water, soil, forests, coal and petroleum.

Q3. When does an element of nature become a resource?

Answer: An element of nature becomes a resource when humans use it to meet their needs or make useful things from it.

Q4. Give an example of nature becoming a resource.

Answer: Trees are part of nature. When humans use their wood to make furniture, trees become a resource.

Q5. What are the three conditions for something to be considered a resource?

Answer: A resource should be:

1. Technologically accessible.
2. Economically feasible to use.
3. Culturally acceptable to use.

Q6. Why can some natural materials not be used as resources?

Answer: Some materials may be difficult to reach, too expensive to extract or culturally unacceptable to use.

Q7. What does the word “exploitation” mean in this chapter?

Answer: It means the extraction, use and consumption of natural resources.

Q8. Give five examples of natural resources.

Answer: Air, water, soil, coal and petroleum.

Topic 2: Categories of Natural Resources

Q1. Why do we categorise natural resources?

Answer: We categorise natural resources to understand them better and group them according to their common characteristics.

Q2. How can natural resources be classified according to their uses?

Answer: They can be divided into three categories:

1. Resources essential for life.
2. Resources for materials.
3. Resources for energy.

Q3. What are resources essential for life?

Answer: These are resources that are necessary for life. Air, water and soil are examples.

Q4. What are resources for materials?

Answer: These are resources used to make useful objects. Wood, marble, iron and gold are examples.

Q5. What are resources for energy?

Answer: These are resources used to produce energy. Coal, petroleum, natural gas, sunlight, wind and flowing water are examples.

Q6. Why is soil important to humans?

Answer: Soil helps us grow crops and produce food. It also supports plant life.

Q7. How is wood useful to humans?

Answer: Wood is used to make furniture, buildings and other useful objects.

Q8. Name three natural resources used to produce energy.

Answer: Coal, petroleum and sunlight.

Topic 3: Restoration and Regeneration

Q1. What is restoration?

Answer: Restoration is the process of bringing something damaged or degraded back to a healthy state.

Q2. What is regeneration?

Answer: Regeneration is nature's ability to create new life and the conditions needed for life to grow.

Q3. How does a forest regenerate naturally?

Answer: When a tree falls, bacteria, fungi and insects decompose it. It becomes part of the soil. New plants grow from seeds, and the cycle continues.

Q4. How can humans help restore a forest?

Answer: Humans can plant suitable native trees, protect wildlife and prevent excessive cutting of trees.

Q5. What is the difference between restoration and regeneration?

Answer: Restoration brings something damaged back to a healthy condition. Regeneration creates new life and supports its growth.

Q6. Why is nature called a recycler?

Answer: Nature reuses materials through natural cycles. For example, dead plants decompose and return nutrients to the soil.

Topic 4: Renewable Resources

Q1. What are renewable resources?

Answer: Renewable resources are resources that nature can renew or replace over time.

Q2. Give five examples of renewable resources.

Answer: Sunlight, wind, flowing water, forests and timber from forests managed sustainably.

Q3. Why is sunlight a renewable resource?

Answer: Sunlight is naturally available again and again and can be used to produce energy.

Q4. Why is flowing water considered renewable?

Answer: Rivers receive water from rainfall and melting glaciers, which replenish their flow.

Q5. Can a renewable resource become depleted?

Answer: Yes. A renewable resource can become depleted if it is used faster than nature can replace it.

Q6. How can forests be used sustainably?

Answer: We should cut trees carefully, plant new trees and allow forests enough time to regenerate.

Q7. What happens when too many fish are caught?

Answer: Overfishing reduces fish populations and disturbs the balance of the ocean ecosystem.

Q8. Why are glaciers important for water security?

Answer: Glaciers feed rivers with meltwater. Many people living in the plains depend on these rivers for water.

Q9. How can human activities disturb nature's cycles?

Answer: Deforestation, fossil-fuel use, industrial pollution and overfishing can disturb nature's cycles.

Q10. What is sustainable use of renewable resources?

Answer: It means using resources at a rate that allows nature to renew them for present and future generations.

Topic 5: Non-Renewable Resources

Q1. What are non-renewable resources?

Answer: Non-renewable resources are resources that take a very long time to form and cannot be replaced as quickly as humans use them.

Q2. Give five examples of non-renewable resources.

Answer: Coal, petroleum, natural gas, iron and copper.

Q3. Why are fossil fuels called non-renewable?

Answer: They take millions of years to form, so nature cannot replace them quickly after they are used.

Q4. Why should coal be used carefully?

Answer: Coal reserves are limited, and burning coal contributes to pollution and rising temperatures.

Q5. How can we reduce the use of non-renewable energy?

Answer: We can save electricity, use public transport and shift to solar, wind and other renewable energy sources.

Q6. What is the difference between renewable and non-renewable resources?

Renewable resources	Non-renewable resources
Can be renewed by natural processes.	Take a very long time to form.

May remain available with sustainable use.	Can be depleted by use.
Examples: sunlight and wind.	Examples: coal and petroleum.

Topic 6: Distribution of Natural Resources and Its Implications

Q1. What is the distribution of natural resources?

Answer: It refers to the way natural resources are spread across different regions of the Earth.

Q2. Are natural resources evenly distributed?

Answer: No. Natural resources are not evenly distributed across the world or even within a country.

Q3. How does the distribution of resources affect human settlements?

Answer: People often settle near water, fertile soil and other useful resources. Industries and towns may also develop near mineral deposits.

Q4. How do natural resources help create employment?

Answer: Industries based on natural resources provide jobs. Towns and other businesses may also grow around these industries.

Q5. What are the disadvantages of resource extraction?

Answer: It may cause pollution, deforestation, displacement of people and damage to sacred places and ecosystems.

Q6. How do natural resources influence trade?

Answer: Regions trade with one another because resources are not available everywhere. Trade helps people obtain resources they lack.

Q7. Why can natural resources cause conflicts?

Answer: Different regions or countries may compete for control over valuable resources such as water, oil and minerals.

Q8. Give an example of a river-water sharing issue in India mentioned in the chapter.

Answer: The sharing of Kaveri River water among Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Puducherry requires negotiation and careful management.

Q9. What is the importance of the mineral distribution map on page 9?

Answer: The map shows the uneven distribution of coal, oil, iron ore and bauxite in India.

Q10. How can resource-related conflicts be reduced?

Answer: They can be reduced through fair sharing, dialogue, cooperation, agreements and responsible management.

Topic 7: The Paradox of Plenty

Q1. What is the paradox of plenty?

Answer: The paradox of plenty means that a region or country may have abundant natural resources but still experience slow economic growth and development.

Q2. What is the natural resource curse?

Answer: It is a situation in which a country rich in natural resources fails to gain the expected economic benefits from them.

Q3. Why does having many natural resources not always make a country rich?

Answer: A country may lack the industries, technology, skills or planning needed to turn raw resources into valuable products.

Q4. How can a country overcome the resource curse?

Answer: It can invest in technology, education, skills and industries that process natural resources into higher-value products.

Q5. What role does good governance play in resource management?

Answer: Good governance helps ensure that resources are used fairly, wisely and sustainably for long-term development.

Topic 8: Responsible and Wise Use of Natural Resources

Q1. What is stewardship of natural resources?

Answer: Stewardship means taking responsibility for protecting nature and using its resources wisely.

Q2. Why should we use natural resources responsibly?

Answer: Responsible use helps reduce pollution, protect biodiversity and preserve resources for future generations.

Q3. What is biodiversity loss?

Answer: Biodiversity loss means a decline in the variety of living things on Earth.

Q4. What are the major effects of irresponsible resource use?

Answer: It can cause pollution, biodiversity loss, climate change, soil degradation and water shortages.

Q5. How can groundwater levels be increased?

Answer: Groundwater levels can be improved through rainwater harvesting, restoring ponds and tanks, reducing water wastage and reusing treated water.

Q6. How can we protect soil fertility?

Answer: We can use compost and cow dung, practise mulching and mixed cropping, and avoid the excessive use of chemical fertilisers and pesticides.

Q7. Why is it important to replenish soil?

Answer: Healthy soil supports plant growth and food production. Replenishing it helps maintain fertility and prevent degradation.

Q8. What does sustainability mean?

Answer: Sustainability means meeting present needs without damaging nature's ability to support future generations.

Topic 9: Overexploitation of Groundwater in Punjab



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Q1. What is overexploitation of groundwater?

Answer: Overexploitation of groundwater means taking water from the ground faster than nature can replace it.

Q2. Why has groundwater decreased in Punjab?

Answer: In the 1960s, farmers started growing high-yielding varieties of wheat and paddy. These crops required more water. Free electricity encouraged excessive pumping of groundwater. Modern farming also increased the use of chemical fertilisers and pesticides.

Q3. What are the effects of groundwater overexploitation in Punjab?

Answer:

1. Groundwater levels have fallen.
2. Water has become difficult to reach.
3. The cost of extracting water has increased.
4. Chemicals from fertilisers and pesticides have polluted groundwater.
5. Water pollution has created health risks.

Q4. What does the textbook say about groundwater overexploitation in Punjab?

Answer: The textbook states that almost 80% of Punjab's area was classified as overexploited. Water was being extracted much faster than it could be naturally replenished.

Q5. How can farmers save groundwater?

Answer: Farmers can use water-saving irrigation methods, grow crops suited to local conditions, harvest rainwater and avoid unnecessary pumping of groundwater.

Q6. What lesson do we learn from Punjab's example?

Answer: We learn that increasing food production in the short term should not damage natural resources needed for the future.

Topic 10: The Case of Cement



Q1. Why is cement important?

Answer: Cement is used to construct houses, schools, hospitals, roads, bridges and airports.

Q2. Why can cement production harm the environment?

Answer: Cement production releases fine dust. This dust can damage the lungs of humans and animals, settle on plant leaves, reduce crop yields and pollute soil and water.

Q3. How can pollution from cement factories be reduced?

Answer: Factories should follow pollution-control guidelines and use cleaner production methods. Alternative building materials can also help reduce pollution.

Q4. Name some alternatives to conventional cement-based construction mentioned in the chapter.

Answer: Traditional materials such as stone and mud, plant-based materials and recycled materials made from waste plastic.

Q5. What are the benefits of sustainable building materials?

Answer: They can reduce pollution, provide local employment and be better suited to the climate of a region.

Q6. What is the importance of combining traditional methods with modern technology?

Answer: It can help create durable and sustainable materials with less pollution and better use of local resources.

Topic 11: Vrikshayurveda

Q1. What is Vrikshayurveda?

Answer: Vrikshayurveda is an ancient Indian system of botanical knowledge that focuses on the study and care of plants and trees.

Q2. What does the word Vrikshayurveda mean?

Answer: Vriksha means tree, and Ayurveda means the science of life or health.

Q3. What does Vrikshayurveda teach us?

Answer: It teaches us about selecting plants for different soils, collecting and preserving seeds, irrigation, natural pest control and caring for soil.

Q4. How does Vrikshayurveda promote sustainable farming?

Answer: It promotes crop rotation, mixed cropping, natural pest repellents and suitable ploughing methods that help retain soil moisture.

Q5. How do earthworms, fungi and bacteria help the soil?

Answer: They support soil health and help decompose organic matter, returning nutrients to the soil.

Q6. Why is traditional agricultural knowledge important today?

Answer: It provides useful methods for protecting soil, conserving water and reducing dependence on harmful chemicals.

Topic 12: The Case Study of Organic Farming in Sikkim



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Q1. What problem did Pema's family face?

Answer: Pema's family faced declining crop yields and increasing debts because of expensive chemical farming inputs.

Q2. What change did Pema's family make?

Answer: The family switched to compost, natural pest repellents made from neem and garlic, and growing multiple crops throughout the year.

Q3. Why did crop yields initially decrease?

Answer: The soil was recovering from years of chemical use.

Q4. What happened after about five years?

Answer: The farm became productive. The family sold cardamom, ginger and traditional vegetables at higher prices.

Q5. When did Sikkim become a fully organic state, according to the chapter?

Answer: Sikkim became a 100% organic state in 2016, with all its farmland certified organic, according to the textbook.

Q6. What were the benefits of organic farming in Sikkim?

Answer:

1. Local biodiversity increased.
2. Beneficial insects and birds returned.
3. Tourism increased.
4. Farmers' incomes grew by 20% on average, according to the chapter.
5. Sustainable farming became a model for other regions.

Q7. What lesson does the Sikkim case study teach us?

Answer: Organic farming and sustainable agricultural practices can protect nature and improve farmers' livelihoods over time.

Topic 13: Responsible and Judicious Use of Non-Renewable Resources

Q1. Why should non-renewable resources be used judiciously?

Answer: They are limited and take a very long time to form. Careful use helps them last longer.

Q2. How can we reduce our dependence on fossil fuels?

Answer: We can use solar and wind energy, save electricity, use public transport and improve energy efficiency.

Q3. What is renewable energy?

Answer: Renewable energy comes from sources that nature can renew, such as sunlight, wind and flowing water.

Q4. Why is solar energy important for India?

Answer: Many parts of India receive abundant sunshine. Solar energy can help meet electricity needs and reduce dependence on fossil fuels.

Topic 14: The International Solar Alliance

Q1. What is the International Solar Alliance?

Answer: The chapter describes an international coalition launched by India and France in 2015 to promote solar energy among countries with abundant sunshine.

Q2. What are the main aims of this alliance, according to the chapter?

Answer: It aims to encourage solar power, share technical knowledge and help make solar projects more affordable.

Q3. What is the importance of the Bhadla Solar Park?

Answer: It is an example of India's efforts to expand solar energy and move towards renewable alternatives.

Q4. How can solar energy help protect the environment?

Answer: Solar energy can reduce the need to burn fossil fuels and help lower pollution associated with conventional energy production.

Q5. How can access to natural resources be unfair?

Answer: Some communities may not receive enough clean drinking water, while others suffer more from air pollution caused by industries and fossil fuels.

Topic 15: Lokasangraha and Our Responsibility Towards Nature

Q1. What is lokasangraha?

Answer: In the chapter, lokasangraha refers to acting for the welfare of all rather than only for personal interests.

Q2. How is lokasangraha connected with natural resources?

Answer: It encourages us to use resources in ways that benefit society as a whole and protect nature for future generations.

Q3. What is our responsibility towards nature?

Answer: We should protect natural resources, prevent pollution, reduce waste and support restoration, regeneration and sustainability.

Part 3: Additional textbook activities — model answers

These questions come from the “Think About It,” “Let’s Explore” and “Don’t Miss Out” sections of the chapter. Some are open-ended, so the answers below are sample answers based on the textbook.

Q1. What criteria can we use to categorise natural resources?

Answer: We can categorise natural resources according to their uses, their ability to regenerate and other shared characteristics. For example, they can be grouped as resources essential for life, resources for materials, resources for energy, renewable resources and non-renewable resources.

Q2. Give examples of traditional practices that show respect for nature.

Answer: Worshipping Tulasi, protecting sacred groves, offering water to the Sun and using natural manure in farming are examples of traditional practices that show respect for nature.

Q3. How can people restore nature's ability to regenerate?

Answer: People can plant trees, restore ponds, reduce pollution, treat industrial waste, save water and use natural farming methods.

Q4. What are ecosystem functions and ecosystem services?

Answer: Ecosystem functions are the natural processes performed by nature. Ecosystem services are the benefits humans receive from these processes.

For example, a forest filters water as an ecosystem function. The clean water people receive is an ecosystem service.

Q5. What non-renewable resources do we use daily, and what renewable substitutes can we use?

Answer: We use petroleum for transport, coal-based electricity and natural gas for cooking and other purposes. Renewable alternatives include solar energy, wind energy, biogas and electricity generated from renewable sources.

Q6. What types of economic activities are connected with natural resources?

Answer: Mining, farming, forestry, fishing, manufacturing, electricity generation and trade are economic activities connected with natural resources.

Q7. What inputs are needed to use natural resources effectively?

Answer: We need human knowledge, skilled workers, technology, investment, industries, good governance and proper planning.

Q8. What are some traditional practices that help maintain ecosystem balance?

Answer: Seasonal restrictions on fishing, protecting sacred groves, collecting rainwater, using organic manure and planting native trees help maintain ecosystem balance.

Q9. How can we use natural resources responsibly for future generations?

Answer: We should avoid overexploitation, conserve water, protect forests, use renewable energy, recycle materials and prevent pollution.

Part 4: Very Important Short Questions and Answers

These are useful for one-mark and two-mark examination questions.

Question	Answer
1. What is a natural resource?	A useful material or substance found in nature.
2. Name two resources essential for life.	Air and water.
3. Name two resources used for making materials.	Wood and iron.
4. Name two renewable energy sources.	Solar energy and wind energy.
5. Name two non-renewable energy sources.	Coal and petroleum.
6. What is overfishing?	Catching fish faster than their populations can recover.
7. What is deforestation?	The clearing or removal of forests.
8. What is soil degradation?	A decline in the quality and health of soil.
9. What is groundwater?	Water stored beneath the Earth's surface.
10. What is organic farming?	Farming that uses organic methods such as compost and natural pest control.

11. What is biodiversity?	The variety of living things in an area or on Earth.
12. What is sustainable development?	Development that meets present needs while protecting the ability of future generations to meet their needs.
13. What is a fossil fuel?	A fuel formed from ancient organic matter over a very long period.
14. What is rainwater harvesting?	Collecting and storing rainwater for later use or to recharge groundwater.
15. What is a natural resource curse?	A situation in which resource-rich regions fail to achieve the expected economic development.
16. What is stewardship?	The responsible care and management of natural resources.
17. Name one traditional Indian botanical science.	Vrikshayurveda.
18. In which year did Sikkim become a 100% organic state, according to the chapter?	2016.
19. Which river's water-sharing issue is discussed in the chapter?	The Kaveri River.
20. What does lokasangraha mean?	Acting for the welfare of all.

Part 5: Important Fill in the Blanks

1. Natural resources occur in _____.

2. Air, water and soil are essential for _____.

3. Coal and petroleum are _____ resources.

4. Sunlight and wind are _____ resources.

5. The decline in the variety of life is called _____ loss.

6. The excessive use of groundwater can lower the water _____.

7. _____ is an ancient Indian botanical science.

8. Sikkim became a 100% organic state in _____.

9. The sharing of _____ River water is discussed in the chapter.

10. Acting for the welfare of all is called _____.

Show All Answers

Part 6: True or False

Natural resources are evenly distributed everywhere.

Sunlight is a renewable resource.

Coal can be replaced quickly after it is used.

Planting trees can help restore forests.

Overexploitation of groundwater can cause water shortages.

Cement production can cause pollution.

Sikkim adopted organic farming throughout the state.

A resource-rich country is always economically prosperous.

Nature's cycles can be disturbed by human activities.

We should use non-renewable resources carefully.

Show Answers

Part 7: Important Multiple-Choice Questions (MCQs)

Practice Test

0/10 answered

1. Which of the following is a non-renewable resource?

A. Sunlight
B. Wind
C. Coal
D. Flowing water

2. Which resource is essential for growing food?

A. Soil
B. Petroleum
C. Gold
D. Natural gas

3. What does restoration mean?

A. Destroying forests
B. Returning something damaged to a healthy state
C. Mining minerals
D. Burning fossil fuels

4. Which state is the example of organic farming in the chapter?

A. Punjab
B. Bihar
C. Sikkim
D. Rajasthan

5. Which river is discussed in the context of water sharing?

A. Ganga
B. Kaveri
C. Narmada
D. Godavari

6. What can help recharge groundwater?

A. Deforestation
B. Rainwater harvesting
C. Over-pumping
D. Water pollution

7. What is the paradox of plenty?

A. A shortage of all resources
B. Abundant resources without expected economic prosperity
C. An increase in rainfall
D. A rise in forest cover

8. What does Vrikshayurveda study?

A. Stars
B. Plants and trees
C. Ocean currents
D. Mineral mining

9. Which of these is a renewable energy source?

A. Coal
B. Petroleum
C. Solar energy
D. Natural gas

10. What is the main aim of sustainable resource use?

A. Use all resources quickly
B. Protect resources for present and future generations
C. Stop all economic activity
D. Increase waste
Check AnswersTry Again

Final Revision: Five Most Important Ideas

1. Natural resources: Materials and substances found in nature that are valuable to humans.
2. Renewable and non-renewable resources: Renewable resources can be renewed naturally; non-renewable resources take a very long time to form.
3. Unequal distribution: Natural resources are not spread evenly, affecting settlements, trade, employment and conflicts.
4. Sustainable use: Resources must be used carefully so that nature can recover and future generations can meet their needs.
5. Case studies: Punjab teaches us about the dangers of groundwater overuse, while Sikkim shows the benefits of organic farming.

This guide covers the chapter's five end-of-chapter questions, its major topics, the key case studies and the principal textbook activities in simple English. The answers are suitable for Class 8 revision and written practice.